WORD SWAPS FOR A SELF-REVIEW THAT GETS READ OUT LOUD IN CALIBRATION

What to write in your self-review

Dennis · Sr PM at Microsoft · @dennisthinks_

1 Swap "helped with" for "led"

"Helped with" gives the work to someone else. If you ran it and made the call, say you led it.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Helped with the Q2 launch."
> Instead say: "Led the Q2 launch: scope, date, and the go/no-go."

2 Swap "worked on" for "shipped"

"Worked on" never ends. "Shipped" comes with a date, and you can put a number after it.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Worked on the pricing page."
> Instead say: "Shipped the pricing page on May 14; conversion up 12% in 30 days."

3 Swap "supported" for "owned"

"Supported" is the word that ends up in the review of the person who didn't get promoted. If it was yours when it broke, you owned it.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Supported the migration."
> Instead say: "Owned the migration plan; 40,000 accounts moved with zero downtime."

4 One number per line

Calibration runs on numbers. If a line doesn't have one, cut it.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Made significant improvements to onboarding."
> Instead say: "Cut onboarding drop-off from 40% to 28%."

5 Name the people who can confirm it

A claim with a name next to it holds up in the room. Name someone who'd back it.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Collaborated closely with engineering."
> Instead say: "Priya's team built it; she has the dashboard."

6 The two words for when you really were only helping

Don't inflate it. Find the piece that was yours and claim that.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
>
> Don't say: "Helped with the platform rollout."
> Instead say: "Owned the comms for the platform rollout: three announcements, zero support tickets about the change."

Check before you send it

- [ ] Is every "helped with" gone or earned?
- [ ] Does every shipped thing have a date?
- [ ] Is there a number on every line?
- [ ] Is there a name who'd confirm it?
- [ ] Did you own the piece instead of inflating the whole?